

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 39 Summary

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In this lesson, I cover the **preterite tense**—the Spanish past tense used for **completed actions**. This is different from the imperfect tense, which we'll learn later. For now, think of the preterite as answering the question: *What happened?*

1. What Is the Preterite Tense Used For?

Use the **preterite** for actions that are:

- Seen as finished or completed
- Occurred at a specific moment in time
- Not describing background information

Examples:

I ate tacos. → Comí tacos.

I went to the store. → Fui a la tienda.

We watched a movie. → Vimos una película.

She told me the truth. → Me dijo la verdad.

You gave him the money. → Le diste el dinero.

These are all actions that are over and done with, and that's what the preterite is for.

2. Conjugation of Regular Verbs in the Preterite

Start by memorizing the **endings**. Then attach them to the verb stem. I recommend starting with **yo** and **tú** forms first, since they're the most commonly used in conversation.

-AR Verbs (e.g., *hablar* – to speak)

Endings:

- yo: **-é**
- tú: **-aste**
- él/ella/usted: **-ó**

- nosotros: **-amos**
- vosotros: **-asteis** (Spain only)
- ellos/ustedes: **-aron**

Examples with *hablar*:

- yo hablé – I spoke
- tú hablaste – you spoke
- él habló – he spoke
- nosotros hablamos – we spoke
- ellos hablaron – they spoke

More examples:

- ¿Hablaste con tu hermana? – Did you speak with your sister?
- Hablé con ella ayer. – I spoke with her yesterday.

-ER and -IR Verbs (e.g., *comer* – to eat, *vivir* – to live)

Endings:

- yo: **-í**
- tú: **-iste**
- él/ella/usted: **-ió**
- nosotros: **-imos**
- vosotros: **-isteis** (Spain only)
- ellos/ustedes: **-ieron**

Examples with *comer*:

- yo comí – I ate
- tú comiste – you ate
- él comió – he ate
- nosotros comimos – we ate
- ellos comieron – they ate

Examples with *vivir*:

- Yo viví en México durante seis años. – I lived in Mexico for 6 years.
- tú viviste... – you lived...
- ella vivió... – she lived...

More examples:

- ¿Ya comiste? – Did you already eat?
 - Sí, ya comí. – Yes, I already ate.
 - Viví en México por dos años. – I lived in Mexico for two years.
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3. Common Irregular Verbs in the Preterite

These don't follow the usual patterns, so you'll need to learn them as a set. Many are extremely high-frequency and appear constantly in everyday Spanish.

Verb	yo	tú	él/ella/Ud.	nosotros	ellos/Uds.
ir / ser	fui	fuiste	fue	fuimos	fueron
hacer	hice	hiciste	hizo	hicimos	hicieron
tener	tuve	tuviste	tuvo	tuvimos	tuvieron
estar	estuve	estuviste	estuvo	estuvimos	estuvieron
poder	pude	pudiste	pudo	pudimos	pudieron
decir	dije	dijiste	dijo	dijimos	dijeron
venir	vine	viniste	vino	vinimos	vinieron
ver	vi	viste	vio	vimos	vieron
dar	di	diste	dio	dimos	dieron

4. Example Sentences with Irregular Verbs

IR / SER (fui, fuiste...)

- Fui a la playa. – I went to the beach.
- ¿Fuiste al cine? – Did you go to the movies?

HACER (hice, hiciste...)

- ¿Qué hiciste ayer? – What did you do yesterday?
- No hice nada. – I didn't do anything.

TENER (tuve, tuviste...)

- Tuve tiempo para estudiar. – I had time to study.
- ¿Tuviste una buena noche? – Did you have a good night?

ESTAR (estuve, estuviste...)

- Estuve en casa toda la noche. – I was home all night.
- ¿Dónde estuviste? – Where were you?

PODER (pude, pudiste...)

- Pude terminar el trabajo. – I was able to finish the work.
- ¿Pudiste hablar con ella? – Were you able to talk with her?

DECIR (dije, dijiste...)

- Le dije la verdad. – I told him the truth.
- Dije que fui a la tienda. – I said I went to the store.

VENIR (vine, viniste...)

- Viniste a la fiesta. – You came to the party.
- ¿Por qué no viniste antes? – Why didn't you come earlier?

VER (vi, viste...)

- Vi una película. – I saw a movie.
- ¿Viste a tu amigo? – Did you see your friend?

DAR (di, diste...)

- Le di un regalo a mi hermano. – I gave a gift to my brother.
- Di las llaves a mi amigo. – I gave the keys to my friend.

5. Tips for Practicing the Preterite

- Say the conjugations out loud. For example, walk around your house saying: *hice, hiciste, hizo...*
- Focus first on the **yo** and **tú** forms.
- Pair conjugations with common time expressions like:
 - ayer (yesterday)
 - anoche (last night)
 - el año pasado (last year)
 - hace una hora (an hour ago)

Example:

- ¿Hablaste con ella ayer? – Did you talk with her yesterday?
 - Sí, hablé con ella anoche. – Yes, I spoke with her last night.
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6. What's Next

Now that you've learned how to use the **preterite** for completed past actions, the next step is learning when to use the **imperfect** tense and how to combine both to tell stories and describe scenes in the past.

But don't move on too fast—**mastering the preterite conjugations is essential** before layering in the imperfect.